A Level 2 Adventure

Fifth Edition Fantasy® #28

Beneath the Isle of Serpents

by Bob Brinkman

The Caverns of Thracia

Goodman Games

5E

BENEATH THE ISLE OF SERPENTS

BY BOB BRINKMAN

5E CONVERSION BY SCOTT MOORE

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For Jennell, a gifted designer and inspirational woman.
Her guiding principles and words of advice will forever continue to shape the lands of Thracia and beyond.

Beneath the Isle of Serpents is an adventure designed for use with the 5th edition of the first fantasy roleplaying game. It is intended for four to six 2nd-level characters and can be completed in one or two sessions. A variety of character classes are suggested to tackle the challenges within the adventure, but a cleric and rogue would be especially advantageous for the party. While set within the Starry Archipelago near the Caverns of Thracia, no additional knowledge or materials are required to run this adventure.

BACKGROUND

Islanders throughout the Starry Archipelago have been disappearing, and the region is nearing the brink of war. Each of the independent island states blames another, and the region is on the verge of erupting into open warfare.

After the fall of the great Shadow Kingdom of the serpentfolk at the hands of the Elder Race, the once fearsome puppet masters retreated into the depths of the world to regroup. Their once global machinations dwindled to nothing as they spent centuries re-establishing a seat of power. Centuries passed, and the once terrifying figures were relegated to legend.

In their struggle for survival, the serpentfolk called upon Set, God of serpents, and entered the service of the dark god. Led by Sss'tk, the demonic high priest of Set, a new Shadow Kingdom has begun to spread its tendrils —using high-placed advisors and powerful priests to whisper into the ears of those in power. Failing that, heads of state can always be replaced. Despite this gradual success, there are those who are impatient to return to past glory. It is that impatience that has brought about the current struggle.

While Sss'tk rules from the center of a subterranean labyrinth, a splinter faction of serpentfolk, led by the serpentfolk wizard Lyanjenlys, has chosen to worship Nehebkau, a primeval demon much older than Set who is destined to usurp Ra as the God of the Sky. It is in its role as guardian of the underworld that the splinter sect serves Nehebkau. It has been gathering sacrifices to further empower Nehebkau for the coming battle with the forces of Set. The recent kidnappings also serve another purpose, to destabilize the region secretly being shepherded by the Shadow Kingdom. So certain of its superiority, the sect has no fear of human reprisal.

The forces of Sss'tk are aware of what is transpiring. While taking measures to seal off the tunnels beneath the Isle of Serpents, they have pushed for a band of reavers to investigate the disappearances. Indeed, it is their own operatives who offer to ferry the characters to the island and to the obvious trail into the jungles. They sincerely hope their rebellious kin will be slain, while simultaneously reducing the number of available surface champions.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

This adventure begins with the characters already present in the Starry Archipelago. It's up to the GM to decide why the characters are here and how they get involved. A few suggestions are presented.

- While plumbing the depths of the Caverns of Thracia, the characters encounter a local fisherman who tells them of the strange goings-on and asks for their help.
- Having just finished their latest adventure, the characters are enjoying the adventure's spoils. They hear rumblings of war, along with rumors about what is *really* going on.
- The party's cleric has been sent word that a group of missionaries near the Thracian peninsula have gone missing and they are charged with discovering what fate may have befallen them.
- The wizard's (or warlock's) patron calls in one of the many debts owed to them. Their patron warns them that an ancient evil is stirring and gaining power. It would please them if those efforts were thwarted.

No matter the method through which they arrive in the Starry Archipelago, the characters' arrival is known to the

serpentfolk. They send one of their servants, an aging fisherman named Kamay, to encourage the characters to explore the island.

Rumors

In addition to the potential adventure hooks, each character has heard at least one of the following rumors:

1. The Isle of Serpents was home to the capital of the Shadow Kingdom of the serpentfolk. (T)
2. An ancient wizard, responsible for shattering the skies over the Starry Archipelago, has been taking prisoners to use in their foul experiments. (F)
3. The volcano at the heart of the island will erupt when the last of the serpentfolk have been exterminated. (F)
4. The Wizards of Caldacia have been kidnapping locals, taking them to the Isle of Serpents, and sacrificing them to their foul patron to gain greater mystical knowledge. (F)
5. Adventurers seeking gold and glory never return from the Isle of Serpents. (T – for now)
6. If these disappearances are not resolved, a regional war is likely to break out in the coming days, as each island nation blames at least one other. (T)
7. Those who worship Set are welcome on the island and are taken to the secret temple beneath the island's surface. (F)
8. The followers of an ancient serpent god have gathered on the island and seek to supplant the power of Set in the region. (T)
9. The serpentfolk of the Shadow Kingdom have been taking prisoners as forced labor for a new temple of Set. (F)
10. Isolated for centuries, the serpentfolk have resorted to harvesting humans within the archipelago as food. (F)

Quest: Defeat Lyanjenlys and either prevent the cultists from summoning Nehebkau or defeat the demon once he arrives. Regardless of the hook used, the characters should discover Lyanjenlys and his cultists performing the summoning ritual and prevent Nehebkau from being unleased upon their world.

Beginning the Adventure

You finally have arrived at the coast of the Starry Archipelago. The people here are grim, acting more furtively the closer it gets to dusk. You were told to seek out a local fisherman named Kamay, so that he could provide you with further information as to the goings-on here. The old fisherman sits with you, loudly sucking his teeth. With skin sunbaked to near leather, and one eye milked over with cataracts, he looks you up and down.

"*Things are getting bad out here,*" he rasps. "*Normally I'd not care a whit for what one gubbermint says about another, but this time they are going to go to war.*" He pauses for a moment, "*Sure, prices soar when there is a war, everyone wants to stockpile everything they can. The value of my catch would likely increase ten-fold, but the danger in bringing in my catch would be one hundred times greater. War may be good for business, but not for the businessman.*"

"*I've seen a lot of comings and goings near the Isle of Serpents,*" he pauses and spits, holding up his fingers in a sign of warding. "*I think that is where the answer to all this can be found, and I implore you to get to the bottom of it. Certainly, adventurers such as you could make short work of whatever is lurking within the old treasure vaults below the sands.*"

"*I can get you to the island; allotting for any weather, it'll take two days. If we circle 'round Typhon's Fang, I can set you down on the south face of the island, safe and sound.*"

The Isle of Serpents

Map 1 depicts the Isle of Serpents.

Fifteen miles north of Typhon's Fang (an ever-raging maelstrom), this island is an unassuming mound of volcanic rock and jungle vegetation. The southern coast of the island is sheltered by numerous reefs, making it an ideal landing point for small craft. The center of the island is dominated by an ancient volcano, long dormant, rising above the tree line. The crumbling visage of a serpentine head is carved into the side of the cone, age and decay making it appear even more sinister. The surface of the black-sand island is dotted with ruined structures, said to once have been inhabited by the serpentfolk of legend.

Rumor is that none who venture to the island ever return, but certainly stories of that sort require a survivor to tell the tale.

If brought by Kamay, the characters begin at the map point marked "X" on the south side of the island; otherwise, they may land at any point they choose. Kamay has chosen the landing point knowing that there is a readily visible trail through the jungle leading from the beach to "A" on the map (a trail recently blazed by the Shadow Kingdom in preparation for the arrival of its pawns). Starting here exposes the characters to an attack by a **giant crab**.

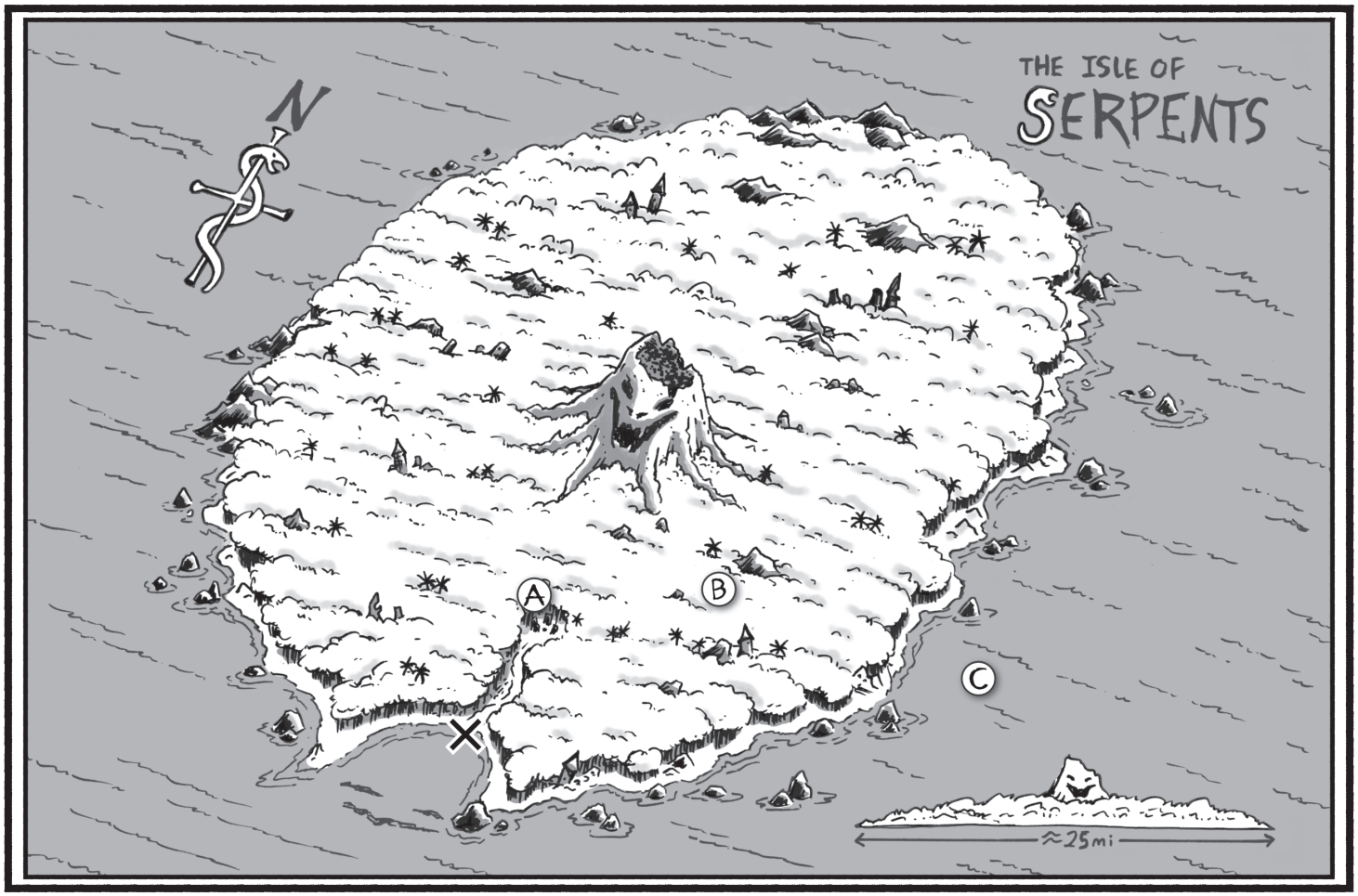
The black sand heaves and pitches, as a massive crab rises from beneath the surface of the beach. It snaps its claws menacingly.

Characters are free to explore the island itself, although it poses many dangers for the unwary. Travel through the jungle, when not using the path, is considered difficult terrain as characters are forced to hack their way through dense brush in many areas. When bushwhacking off trail, roll on the Overland Encounters table for each two hexes traveled.

Table 1-1 - Overland Encounters

1d20	Encounter
1-2	A flock of brightly colored birds are startled by the characters' approach. They noisily take flight, startling the party and potentially drawing the attention of something larger. Those with a passive Wisdom (Perception) of 14 or above notice the giant millipede moving in to attack the party before it strikes. Giant millipedes use the **giant centipede** statistics, but with a speed of 50 feet and a climb of 50 feet.
3	The characters come across a ruined village of crumbling, heavily overgrown stone buildings. The jungle incursion, coupled with the poor state of the buildings, complicates and slows any search. However, a full 30 minutes of searching uncovers a hidden cache of ancient gold coins (250 gp), minted in the ancient kingdom of Thracia, located far south of the archipelago. How they came to be here is impossible to determine.
4	The characters stumble across the body of a recently deceased human. The corpse shows signs of ill-treatment and captivity, with clear marks from manacles showing on their wrists. Flies buzz around the body and the corpse is from the past several days. The body is clothed only in rags and has no other possessions.
5	A scouting party of two **serpentfolk** of the Shadow Kingdom (see appendix A; these serpentfolk have AC 13 and are wearing studded leather armor) observes the characters and are concerned by their presence away from the marked path to area A. They move to a safe distance from the party and make noise to draw their attention, hoping to lead them back towards the target area. If discovered by the party, they flee in the direction of area A but, if confronted, gladly give their lives in service to the Shadow Kingdom.
6-7	The characters stumble across a splinter tribe of 20 **primeval serpentfolk** (see appendix A), having de-evolved after being abandoned by their brethren long ago. The tribe's village consists of simply constructed huts, and the serpentfolk live openly, having lost their illusion ability. They are distrustful, but not hostile unless pressed. If approached in good faith, they tell the characters of the "cobra heads" who have been bringing prisoners to the island, and point them towards area A. If attacked, they fight without mercy but flee into the jungle if reduced by a quarter of their number.
8	The characters find the remains of an adventuring party. Amidst the bleached bones they discover 117 sp, 25 gp, one set of thieves' tools, a suit of rusted chainmail (AC 15), a holy symbol (Justicia), two flasks of oil, a moldering spell book (one 3rd-level spell of the GM's discretion is still legible), and a pair of wooden clubs. All else has succumbed to the elements.
9	Beneath a small cairn of rocks lies the body of a halfling. The corpse has no equipment and appears to have been mauled by a large animal.
10-11	The characters encounter a troop of soldiers (treat as lawful neutral human **scouts** with AC 16 due to scale mail) from one of the island nations. They immediately blame the characters for the rash of recent disappearances and attack. If captured and questioned, they reveal their nation is about to launch an attack on a neighboring island in three days, which will plunge the archipelago into war.
12	The characters stumble upon a rock outcropping that has naturally formed into the shape of a human face. An oracular spirit is contained within and speaks in a voice akin to the whispering of the wind. It truthfully answers 1d4 + 2 "yes or no" questions, as per a *commune* spell. If asked to forecast a future event, the GM is encouraged to randomly determine the answer and, when the appropriate time comes, the characters in question should be granted advantage or suffer disadvantage to their actions. If the fate is negative, but still overcome, those involved gain inspiration.
13-14	The characters disturb a **swarm of rats**, which immediately surges forward and attack.
15	Three **serpentfolk** followers of Lyanjenlys (see appendix A; these serpentfolk have AC 13 and are wearing studded leather armor) stumble across the characters and immediately attempt to capture them. They use non-lethal attacks until one of them has been slain.

16	The characters stumble across a banana grove, laden with ripe fruit. If picked, the fruit provides provisions enough for four days before beginning to rot.
17-18	A swarm of mosquitos descends on the party to feed. A swarm of mosquitos uses the **swarm of insects** statistics, but with the following change: • On a successful Bites attack, the target must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution save or become infected with disease. Once infected, the target shows no sign of disease for 48 hours. After which, they are wracked with fever and muscle aches for 2d6 days, suffering a level of exhaustion each day (not cumulative) until the illness passes. Each successive infectious bite suffered adds +2 days to the duration of the disease. Once the illness has run its course, the target's Constitution score is reduced by 1d4 until they complete their next long rest.
19-20	A foul stench of rotting flesh hangs in the air, the attractive scent of a **giant corpse flower** (see below), a massive carnivorous plant. Should the party investigate and be drawn within 20 feet of the plant's tremendous bloom, it lashes out with its tendrils, attempting to feed.



Map 1

GIANT CORPSE FLOWER

This large, vine-covered carnivorous plant produces a single massive flower that, when in bloom, produces a scent like that of decaying flesh. It does so in hopes of luring a potential scavenger close enough to grapple with its tendrils, enabling it to feed.

GIANT CORPSE FLOWER

Large Plant, Unaligned

Armor Class: 11 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 57 (6d10 + 24)

Speed: 0 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
16 (+3)	11 (+0)	18 (+4)	5 (-3)	8 (-1)	5 (-3)

Saving Throws: Con +6

Damage Vulnerabilities: fire

Condition Immunities: blinded, deafened, frightened

Senses: blindsight 30 ft. (blind beyond this radius), passive Perception 9

Languages: —

Challenge: 2 (450 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

False Appearance: While the giant corpse flower remains motionless, it is indistinguishable from an ordinary plant.

ACTIONS

Multiattack: The giant corpse flower makes three Tendril attacks. It may replace one of the Tendril attacks with a Bite.

Tendril: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 20 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) bludgeoning damage and the target is grappled (escape DC 13). Until this grapple ends, the target is pulled 10 feet closer to the creature and suffers 4 additional bludgeoning damage each round.

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 4 piercing damage, and the target must make a DC 13 Constitution saving throw, taking 3 (1d6) acid damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one.

This massive flowering plant produces a scent not unlike that of decaying flesh.

AREA A: VILLAGE RUINS

Map 2 depicts the underground passages. **Map 3** depicts a side view of the underground chambers.

Oddly, the jungle's verdant growth halts at the edge of this clearing, its border being as crisp as a razor cut. The deforested area is dotted with the remains of crumbling buildings, their ancient blocks of volcanic rock having long since given way to the elements. Some soar as high as thirty feet into the air, while most are much smaller. None look particularly stable, or safe, save for perhaps being an emergency shelter from the elements.

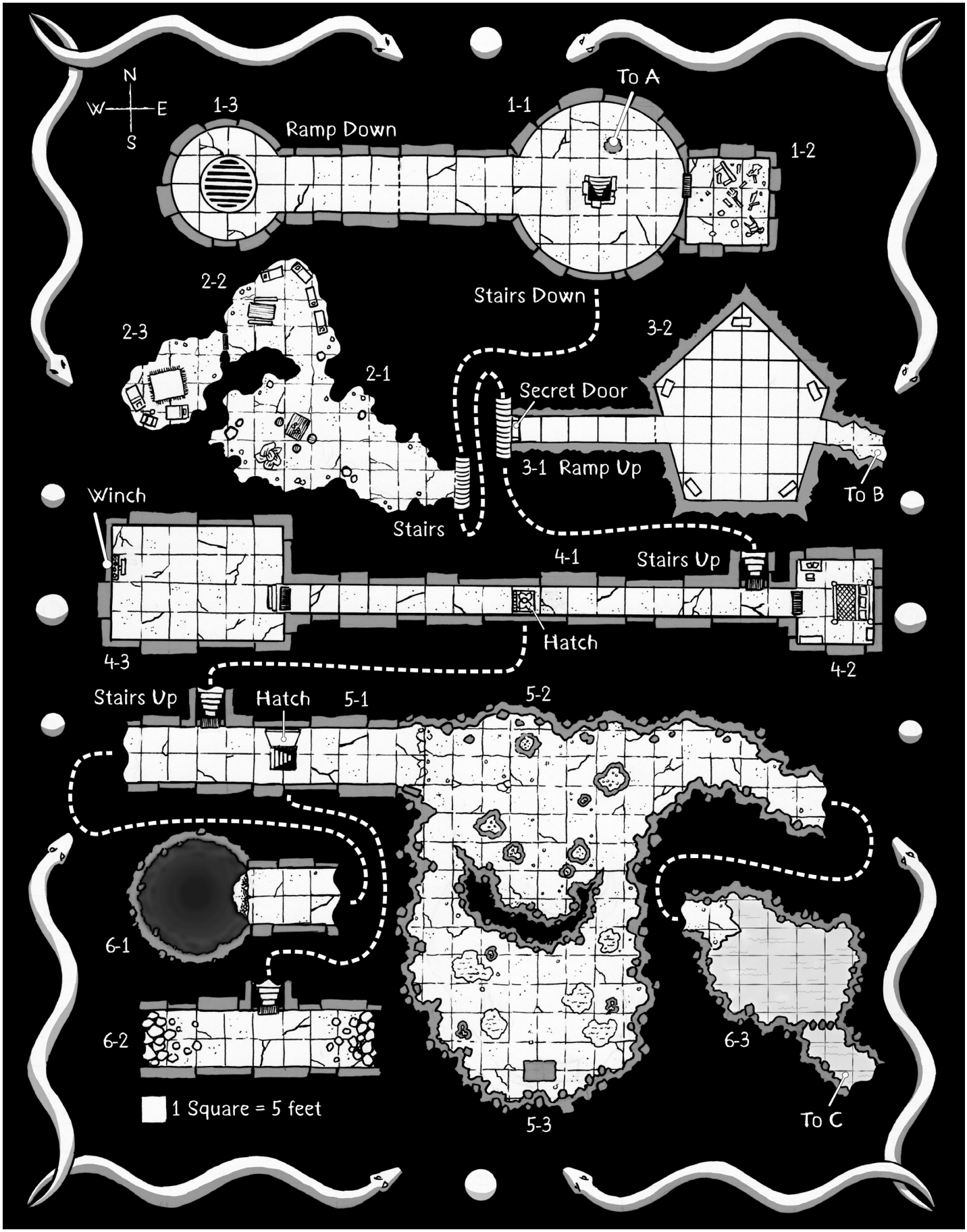
The blazed trail through the jungle leads to this long-abandoned village. None of the larger structures are sound, something that is readily visible to even the most casual observer. A clear footpath of both shod and barefoot tracks leads to a small 10-foot square structure. There is a narrow, three-foot-wide chimney which descends underground. Old, dead roots choke the way down, making descent slow going, but easily passable for even the least-skilled climbers (DC 10 Strength (Athletics) check). The passage descends fifty feet before opening into the ceiling of area 1-1.

AREA B: THE WAY DOWN

Concealed beneath twenty years of heavy jungle growth, this tunnel leads to area 3-2. While the passage appears, at first glance, to be a natural fissure stretching over the course of two miles, that is not the case. This passage was created by the elder thing (see area 3-2), using advanced technology to burrow through the substrate in mere minutes. A character succeeding on a DC 15 Intelligence (Nature) check recognizes that something is unusual with this passage, while a 20 or higher on the check allows them to realize this natural looking passage is wholly artificial and has been somehow excavated through means that they cannot understand. Dwarves with Stonecunning have advantage on this check.

AREA C: UNDERWATER EXIT

The underwater passage from area 6-3 emerges here, 200 feet beneath the surface. The characters cannot find this passage from the surface, nor can they traverse it, without using magical means.


N
W
E
S
1-3
Ramp Down
1-1
To A
1-2
2-2
2-3
2-1
Stairs Down
3-2
Secret Door
3-1 Ramp Up
To B
Winch
Stairs
4-1
Stairs Up
Hatch
4-3
4-2
Stairs Up
Hatch
5-1
5-2
6-1
6-2
6-3
1 Square = 5 feet
5-3
To C

Map 2

SERPENT STAIRS

The stairways beneath the isle were designed to be difficult for non-serpentfolk to traverse. At barely three feet wide, it is impossible to take them in a fashion other than single file. Furthermore, as the stairs weave back and forth, it makes maneuvering through them in medium or heavy armors even more difficult, reducing movement by half and inflicting disadvantage on Dexterity saving throws. Plate and half plate armors are the most problematic, noisily rasping along the sides of the stairs, individuals wearing them automatically fail Dexterity (Stealth) checks and alert all below to the presence of intruders.

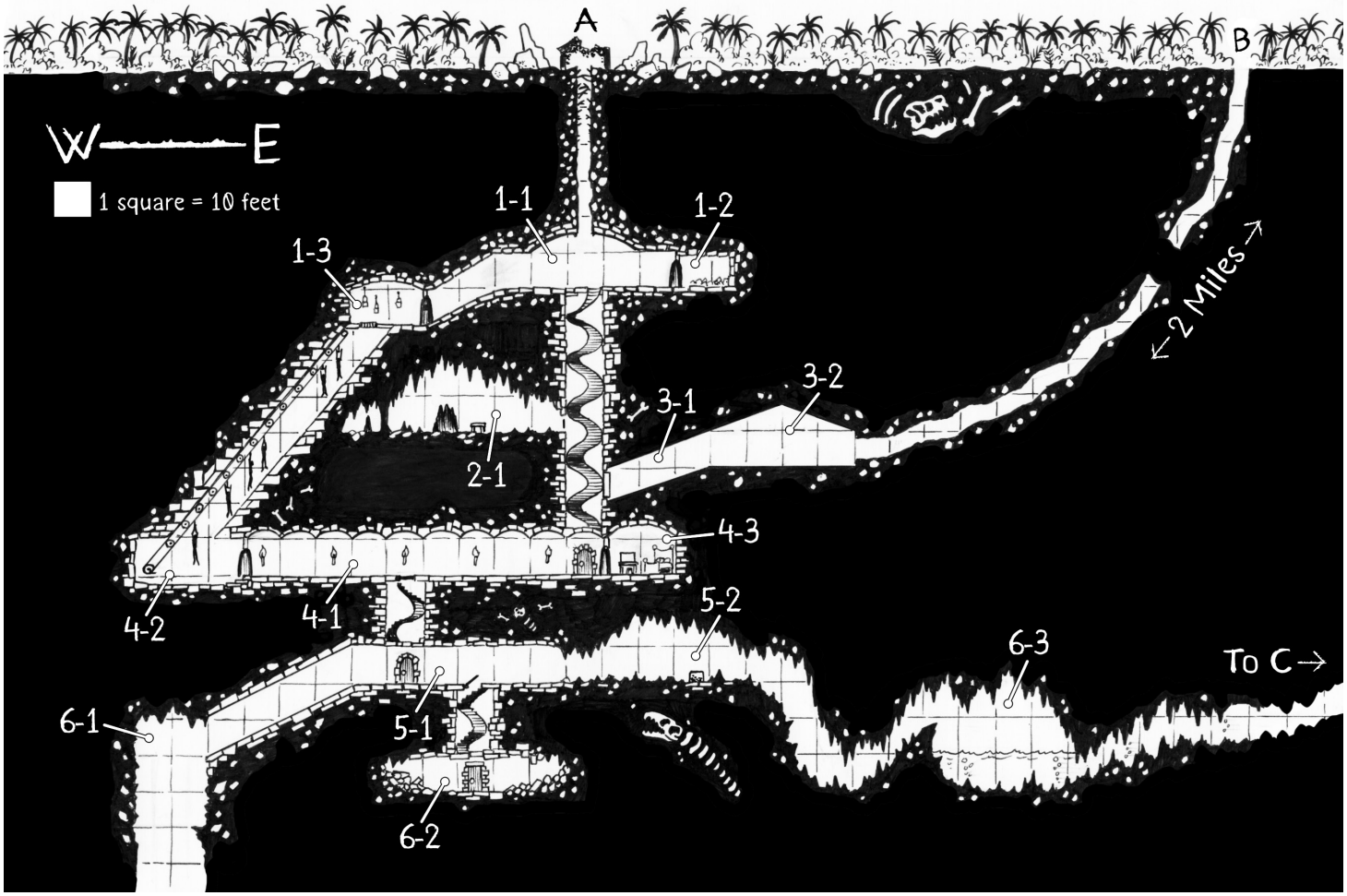
As a reminder, it takes one minute to doff medium armor and five minutes to don it. Heavy armor takes five minutes to doff and 10 minutes to don.

SERPENT ARMOR

Serpentfolk take advantage of their body's greater flexibility, designing multi-plated armors that allow them to move and flex without hindrance. For serpentfolk, this eliminates any Stealth penalty associated with the armor. Further, a proficient smith can shorten serpent half plate by removing some of the panels, allowing it to be worn by any Medium or Small size humanoid.

AREA 1-1: FRESCO CHAMBER

This is a small chamber, roughly fifteen feet in diameter, its walls covered in the crumbling remnants of what were brightly colored frescoes. Time and dampness have brought them to near unrecognizable ruin, with only small details surviving here and there. A single sputtering torch illuminates a swollen wooden door to the east and a downward sloping passage to the west. In the center of the room is a narrow stairway descending into the gloom.



Map 3

A foul odor can be smelled from the west, as the reek of unwashed captives rises through the hanging shaft and towards the surface. Entering the passage increases the concentration of the stench to a point where it is so thick that the party chokes on the foul taste carried in the air. The door to the east is swollen by centuries of humidity and neglect, making it impossible to open in the traditional sense. However, the wood is so rotten that it is possible to simply kick through it (AC 15, 5 hit points, immunity to poison and psychic damage).

Closely inspecting the remaining fragments of the frescoes reveals glimpses of several serpent-headed figures. Each is on a different section of wall, and a successful DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) check reveals that they are each seated in a throne room or temple chamber. Truly a reflection of the Shadow Kingdom as it once was.

The stairs sharply switchback downwards, descending past areas 2-1 and 3-1, and ending at area 4-1.

AREA 1-2: GUARD POST

Behind the rotting door is a small chamber. From the looks of what remains, it may have once been a guard room. A table and several chairs lie broken on the floor. Lying against the wall is a pile of badly corroded metal, rust glistening wetly.

The pile of metal is a combination of scimitar blades (their hilts having long ago rotted away) and a suit of now useless serpentfolk plate armor. Any character with an appropriate background (armorer, dwarf, smith, et al.) notices the strange construction of the armor. With a successful DC 15 Intelligence check they realize the armor was built to maximize flexibility, perhaps even beyond what a normal body is capable of.

Breaching the door and disturbing the rusting remains does come with consequence though. Doing so disturbs a **swarm of corrosion midges** (see below), which immediately seeks to devour fresh metals brought into the room. The swarm is hungry, but not insatiable. After scoring a total of 1d4 + 2 hits they will settle down again, unable to devour anything further for 24 hours.

SWARM OF CORROSION MIDGES

This swarm is not attracted to flesh, instead devouring ferrous metals such as iron and steel. When succeeding in their attack against a metal object, the surface area of the item is immediately covered in a thick, sloughing rust. If no armor or weapons are available for them to feed upon, corrosion midges will burrow into packs and pouches, destroying a mundane item such as an iron spike, or reducing the effectiveness of a prized tool.

SWARM OF CORROSION MIDGES

Medium Swarm of Tiny Beats, Unaligned

Armor Class: 12 (natural armor)
Hit Points: 22 (5d8)
Speed: 5 ft., fly 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
3 (-4)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)	1 (-5)	7 (-2)	1 (-5)

Damage Vulnerabilities: fire
Damage Resistance: bludgeoning, piercing, slashing
Condition Immunities: charmed, frightened, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, prone, restrained, stunned
Senses: blindsight 10 ft., passive Perception 8
Languages: —
Challenge: 1 (200 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Detect Iron: The swarm can pinpoint the presence of ferrous metal within 30 feet of it.
Swarm: The swarm can occupy another creature's space and vice versa, and the swarm can move through any space large enough for a Tiny insect. The swarm can't regain hit points or gain temporary hit points.

ACTIONS

Multiattack: The swarm makes two attacks: one with its Bites and one with its Corrosion.

Bites: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +3 to hit, reach 0 ft., one target in the swarm's space. *Hit:* 10 (4d4) piercing damage, or 5 (2d4) piercing damage if the swarm has half its hit points or fewer.

Corrosion: The swarm corrodes a nonmagical ferrous item in its space. If the item isn't being worn or carried, the touch destroys a 1-foot cube of it. If the object is being worn or carried by a creature, the creature can make a DC 11 Dexterity saving throw to avoid the swarm's corrosion ability.

If the object touched is either metal armor or a metal shield being worn or carried, it takes a permanent and cumulative -1 penalty to the AC bonus it offers. Armor reduced to an AC of 10 or a shield that drops to a +0 bonus is destroyed. If the object touched is a held metal weapon or a piece of ammunition, the object takes a permanent and cumulative -1 penalty to damage rolls. If its penalty drops to -5, the weapon or piece of ammunition is destroyed.

This swarm of buzzing insects is accompanied by an oddly metallic smell.

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AREA 1-3: THE DRAIN

The air here is foul to the point of barely being breathable. Set into the floor is a heavy round grating, presumably from whence the miasmatic vapors are emanating. The floor here is damp, and several buckets hang on the walls. Faint light glimmers from below, casting this barren chamber into murky relief.

The grating is built into the floor and not meant to be opened. There is no lock or latch to allow for such and pulling it free via brute force requires a successful DC 25 Strength (Athletics) check, making it near impossible.

Looking through the bars into the gloom, reveals twelve dark shapes suspended from the sloping ceiling of the shaft. Individuals with darkvision can make out the shapes are human captives, hanging from shackles attached to a chain that runs along the shaft's ceiling, seemingly barely alive. The shaft slants downwards to an indeterminate distance. The mechanism to cycle the captives up and down is found in area 4-2.

AREA 2-1: CASINO CAVERN

Above you, this natural cavern rises to 20 feet in some places, with finger-sized stalactites clinging to the ceiling. A pair of torches illuminate the chamber, casting their light upon a trio of stools and a table glinting with small coins and a pair of bone dice. Next to the table is a heap of rags and sundry items, tossed there with little care. A curving passage leads outwards from the north.

This chamber is an active guard post. If made aware of the characters' approach, the two **serpentfolk** (see appendix A) and **cobra-headed serpentfolk sub-commander** (see appendix A; this sub-commander has AC 15 and wears serpent half plate armor) in this area attack as soon as the first in line draws near enough. The guards use the presence of the first in line to shield them from further attack while one of them seeks to Hypnotize the next in line into turning on the party. If caught unaware, the guards are within the chamber, dicing over the meager possessions of the most recently arrived captives.

On the floor are four sets of clothing, as well as: a mendicant beggar's bowl, a club, cheese dip, a set of smith's tools, a gravedigger's shovel and trowel, and a longsword. The cobra-headed serpentfolk sub-commander also has the keys to unlock the doors in area 4-2 and area 4-3 concealed in the folds of his hood.

Treasure. Atop the table are 178 cp, 14 sp, and a cowrie necklace (locally worth 2 gp, worthless elsewhere), the total wealth of the most recent captives. Sitting amidst the coinage is a pair of *lucky dice*.

NEW MAGIC ITEM

LUCKY DICE

Wondrous item, rare (requires attunement)

These bone dice look like other carved, knucklebone dice. When used by someone aware of their potential, however, they can be subtly affected by force of will. When these dice are in use, you are considered to have proficiency with a gaming set (dice set). If you already have this proficiency, you are considered to have expertise instead, allowing you to add double your proficiency bonus to any ability checks made with these dice.

You do not need to be the person tossing the bones, and may impact any roll of these dice, so long as you are able to see the faces of the dice clearly.

Once per day, you may add 1d10 to a single ability check made with the dice.

A rogue holding these dice feels a brief tingle and is innately aware of how they function. Being wholly a product of fortune, and the gambler's understanding of it, the dice do not radiate magic, as per a permanent *magic aura* spell using the False Aura trait. Such dice are highly prized among the unscrupulous, and are worth 500 gp or more, depending on the social circles the buyer moves in. Such dice might be worth up to 1,000 gp to one who gambles among nobility.

AREA 2-2: BUNK ROOM

This natural cavern has been converted into living quarters. Seven triple-bunk beds are against the eastern wall, with eleven leather satchels hanging on the wall alongside them. The center of the room is dominated by a pair of simple tables with benches that obviously serve as a communal eating area. Beyond the tables, several large meat hooks dangle from the ceiling although, fortunately, they are currently unoccupied. Near the western wall there is a large workspace, its surface scarred by cleaver marks and stained with old blood.

The core of the serpentfolk forces reside here when off-duty. Of the 24 serpentfolk housed here, 10 of them are currently off the island, capturing and bringing back more sacrifices for Nehebkau. The room is currently unoccupied.

Behind the counter is a barrel containing severed hands, feet, and other pieces of humanoid limbs, butchered down to a size that the serpentfolk can swallow whole. Next to the barrel is a natural fissure that drops into the darkness, allowing unman-

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ageable pieces to be cast away into the depths below the island where they are neatly turned to ash by magma flows.

Treasure. The leather satchels hanging from the beds each hold 9 (2d8) sp, bits of unidentified meat, and pieces of worthless bone jewelry. If examined closely with a successful DC 10 Intelligence (Investigation) or Wisdom (Medicine) check, the jewelry can be identified as having been carved from human bones.

AREA 2-3: COMMANDERS' QUARTERS

A pair of serviceable, yet comfortable looking, cots have been set up in this room. The décor here is several steps above the starkly furnished barracks outside. A thick rug covers much of the floor, and a small table and pair of chairs are pressed against the wall. A small chest rests at the foot of each bed.

These are the quarters of the two **cobra-headed serpentfolk sub-commanders** (see appendix A). The room is occupied by whichever is off-duty, and there is a 25% chance that they are sleeping when the door is first opened. Whether asleep or awake, while off-duty and relaxing they are not wearing their serpent half plate armor (giving them AC 12), which is on an armor stand in the corner.

The footlockers contain the gathered treasures of the two sub-commanders, items taken from human prisoners and sacrifices.

Treasure. The first chest contains 200 cp, 30 sp, 5 gp, three mithril ingots (each worth 100 gp), a tarot deck (1 gp value), and a deer pelt (worth 5 gp). The second chest holds 60 cp, 28 sp, 8 gp, a black grimoire (containing 1d4 + 2 1st-level spells of the GM's choice), a gold ring (20 gp), and a child's doll.

AREA 3-1: UNEARTHLY PASSAGE

The secret door leading to this room from the stairwell requires a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check to discover. The secret door is trapped (requiring a second successful DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) check to locate), pouring two flasks worth of thick, tarry oil on anyone opening the door (a successful DC 15 Dexterity save avoids the oil). The ignition source has long since been fouled by the dampness and only triggers on a result of 1 on a d6. If ignited, the burning oil inflicts 1d6 fire damage per round, and requires the target to spend two consecutive rounds to fully extinguish.

This upward sloping passageway is constructed like no other that you have ever encountered. The basalt walls, floor, and ceiling are perfectly smooth and polished to a near mirror sheen and are utterly without flaws. Motes of orange light hang in the air, illuminating this passageway, as well as the chamber above.

A character with Stonecunning immediately feels ill at ease on this ramp--its construction is too perfect to be possible. A successful DC 15 Intelligence (History) check made with Stonecunning leads to the conclusion that this passageway was not carved or worked, rather the stone was disintegrated via some form of magic or tool wholly unknown to the characters. Arcane spellcasters and fey entering the hallway that succeed on a DC 10 Wisdom saving throw feel uneasy as they sense that this is the work of an ancient and alien intelligence from beyond mortal understanding.

AREA 3-2: PENTAGONAL LABRATORY

Like the ramp leading into this chamber, the walls here are perfectly formed. There are no seams or toolmarks, just the gleam of polished stone. Within this pentagonal chamber is a hidden laboratory. Multicolored crystalware, stained with the gum-like remains of what fluids they once held, sit on the quintet of workspaces ringing the room. Strange tools, shaped for no earthly hand, are positioned throughout the room as well. However, the prime focus of the room is something akin to nothing that mortal eyes have beheld for centuries.

Having come here to study the surviving serpentfolk, this **elder thing** (see below) was injured in a lab experiment several months ago and is still recovering (it has 15 hit points remaining). Highly intelligent, it does not attack unless provoked, and understands the impact that its form can have on creatures of lesser intellect. It sees the characters as lesser beings, although it recognizes arcane spellcasters (and to a lesser extent, fey creatures) as kindred explorers of esoteric sciences.

If amicable communication is established, the elder thing attempts to convey that it is studying a splinter faction of serpentfolk, flashing images via telepathy of both common serpentfolk, followed by images of cobra-headed individuals. It gives an impression of disharmony between the groups but cannot simplify its language enough to clearly communicate any real detail.

Triggering the trap outside the secret door leaves clear evidence of the existence of the elder thing's observation post, and it will begin to pack its lab for departure after being encountered. If the chamber is entered a second time, the contents of the lab are gone, and only the twisting passage upwards (to area B on the surface) remains to show that anything was ever here.

ELDER THING

Hailing from another realm, elder things (also known as the Elder Race) are ancient creatures whose natural curiosity occasionally motivates them to peer into other realities. Responsible long ago for the original fall of the serpentfolk's Shadow Kingdom, elder things are entirely alien in appearance and nearly beyond the comprehension of most intelligent creatures. Those who gaze upon the true form of an elder thing frequently experience temporary insanity.

ELDER THING

Huge Aberration, Typically Lawful Neutral

Armor Class: 14 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 47 (5d12 + 15)

Speed: 30 ft., fly 50 ft. (hover)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
15 (+2)	16 (+3)	17 (+3)	19 (+4)	18 (+4)	23 (+6)

Saving Throws: Dex +5, Con +5, Wis +6

Skills: Perception +6

Condition Immunities: frightened

Senses: blindsight 200 ft., passive Perception 14

Languages: Elder Thing, telepathy 120 ft.

Challenge: 3 (700 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Alien Caster: Due to its wholly alien nature, the elder thing's spellcasting is completely unrecognizable by traditional spellcasters. As such, it cannot be countered (via *counterspell*), nor does it require any traditional components (material, somatic, or verbal).

Amphibious: The elder thing can breathe air and water.

Mind Bending: The form of an elder thing is so wholly alien that it immediately triggers the fight, flight, or freeze response in intelligent creatures (other than serpentfolk). On encountering an elder thing for the first time, creatures must succeed on a DC 12 Wisdom save or suffer one of the effects in the Elder Thing Mind-Bending Results table. Once a creature has successfully saved against this effect, they are immune to Mind-Bending for all future encounters with members of the Elder Race, although they always feel a sense of disquiet. Arcane spellcasters make this save with advantage, due to their greater exposure to the mysteries of eldritch magic, while fey creatures make it with disadvantage.

ACTIONS

Multiattack: The elder thing can make up to five Tentacle attacks. It can replace three of these attacks with Spellcasting.

Tentacle: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) bludgeoning damage.

Spellcasting: The elder thing casts one of the following spells, requiring no material components and using Charisma as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 16):

- At will: *comprehend languages*
- 2/day each: *dispel magic, shield*
- 1/day each: *color spray, magic missile, ray of enfeeblement, shatter*

The creature has a five-faceted, barrel-shaped body, with massive, serrated-edged wings extending from one side. In place of a head, there is a five-pointed protrusion, covered in grasping cilia that sway in the air. Instead of legs, another, wider, five-pointed base emerges from below, somehow allowing this blasphemous thing physical locomotion. From each side extends a grasping tentacle, moving sinuously through the air.

Table 1-2: Elder Thing Mind-Bending Results

1d4	Result
1	*Fight:* Onlooker immediately enters a battle rage for 1d4+1 rounds and attacks every creature around them, both friend and foe. While in battle rage, the onlooker inflicts an additional 1d12 damage (of the same type of the weapon used) on each successful hit. When the battle rage ends, the character gains two levels of exhaustion.
2-3	*Flight:* Onlooker is frightened for 2d4 rounds and flees via the nearest means of egress. They will attack, to their utmost ability, anything that tries to prevent their escape; seeking to kill companions, smashing through barricades, etc.
4	*Freeze:* Onlooker's brain is unable to grasp the meaning of what they are gazing upon and shorts out, leaving them incapacitated for 3d4 rounds. During this fugue state, they are wholly unaware of what transpires around them. Upon awakening from this state, they are unaware of what has occurred for the past 1d6 × 10 minutes prior to encountering the elder thing.

AREA 4-1: THE LONG HALL

This east-west hallway is lit by torches at twenty-foot intervals. The walls are adorned with still-bright mosaics, depicting serpentfolk leading lines of chained captives towards a looming temple. The iconography, however, has been deliberately defaced with deep gouges in the plaster. Doors are set at either end. Roughly halfway down the hall's length, a gilded hatchway is set into the floor.

A successful DC 12 Intelligence (Religion) check reveals that the temple depicted is devoted to the god Set.

The western door has a barred window at eye-level and allows one to see into area 4-2, although the guardian serpent is against the door and cannot be seen via ordinary means. Both doorways in this hallway are locked, requiring a successful DC 12 Dexterity check with thieves' tools to open.

The gilding on the hatch is merely that, gilding. The hatchway is both locked (requiring a successful DC 15 Dexterity check with thieves' tools to open) and trapped with a *glyph of warning*, requiring a successful DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation) check to notice. Once the glyph is activated, a *scorching ray* spell (all three rays) targets the individual who triggered it (+6 to hit; 2d6 fire damage per ray that hits). If the target of the spell has a Chaotic aspect to their alignment, the attacks have advantage.

AREA 4-2: THE PRISON

A portion of this room is visible through the barred window of the door. A pair of torches illuminate the dank and dismal chamber beyond. At the far end of the room, a large winch is set into the wall, connected to a chain that runs along the ceiling and disappears into a shaft above. Hanging from a nearby peg is a ring, laden with several heavy keys.

Concealed behind the door, and below the view of the window, is a giant two-headed viper which serves as the guardian of this chamber. It immediately attacks anyone opening the door who is not an undisguised serpentfolk (as it cannot otherwise tell the difference). If the viper hasn't already been detected, the creature gains surprise on its first attack.

The giant two-headed viper is a **giant poisonous snake** with

the following changes, which increase its challenge rating to 1/2 (100 XP):

- **Two Heads:** The snake has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks and on saving throws against being blinded, charmed, deafened, frightened, stunned, and knocked unconscious.
- **Wakeful:** When one of the snake's heads is asleep, its other head is awake.
- **Multiattack:** The giant two-headed viper makes two Bite attacks.

Looking up into the upward sloping shaft is a grim sight, revealing 12 malnourished prisoners, all of whom have been roughly treated. They are clad only in thin rags and their manacled hands leave them dangling from the chain above them. Between harsh treatment and squalid conditions, 10 are near death (treat as **commoners**, each with 1 hit point remaining), and two have already expired, their bodies beginning to rot.

The winch operates a pulley system that moves the chain, cycling the prisoners up and down into the chamber and the set of keys for their manacles. If released, the prisoners are still very weak and unable to act on their own without first being healed. Upon escape, they are beholden to their rescuers and may join the party or be useful contacts during future adventures in the region.

AREA 4-3: LYANJENLYS' QUARTERS

These well-appointed quarters are cared for and comfortable. While the frescos on the wall have been damaged by the passage of time, everything here is neat and tidy. The bed is heavily cushioned, and a small writing desk sits off to one side. Several slender volumes sit upon the desktop, one of which is open.

These are the personal quarters of Lyanjenlys, benefactress of her patron Nehebkau and leader of this rebellious sect. The books on the writing desk are collected histories of the nations of the archipelago, with the open volume being a history of the Isle of Venicus, the former sanctum of the wizard Ceronomus Caesaro, who was responsible for splitting the skies asunder above the archipelago. The notes contained therein may inspire further adventuring in the regions surrounding Thracia. In the desk drawer is a handwritten ledger, detailing which humans have been replaced by Lyanjenlys' subordinates, providing the GM with fodder for future confrontations.

Beneath the bed is a small, locked chest (requiring a successful DC 15 Dexterity check with thieves' tools to open) protected by a simple needle trap. The trap requires a successful DC 12 Intelligence (Investigation) check to discover, and only a successful DC 10 Dexterity check with thieves' tools to disarm. The poison on the needle, however, is derived from Lyanjenlys' own concentrated venom, and is quite potent if triggered (1 piercing damage plus the target must succeed on a DC 16 Constitution save or gain the poisoned condition for 1 hour. While poisoned, the target is blinded).

Treasure. The chest contains a golden serpent idol of Nehebkau (800 gp), a devotional to Nehebkau (allowing a warlock to take the ancient demon as a patron), and 10 large pearls (worth 50 gp each).

AREA 5-1: ACRID HALL

The hallway here is lit by a deep orange glow originating from the east. The air here is thick with the tang of sulfur. A gilded hatchway is open, revealing the narrow, switchback stairs leading downwards. To the west, a dark passage slopes downwards, its surface glistening with moisture.

Harsh voices and the sounds of ringing pickaxes from below are noticed by anyone succeeding on a DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check.

AREA 5-2: ACID DRIP

This natural cavern is dotted with miniature lava domes, looking akin to raised craters filled with molten magma. The air here is hot and humid, with the tell-tale stench of brimstone clinging to everything. Here and there, water drips from the ceiling, steaming as it hits the floor. The southern wall is curved into a u-shape, and passages lead south from both the east and west sides.

The dripping "water" is sulfuric acid formed by condensation mixed with the volcanic ash in the air. Victims who are knocked prone must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution save or suffer 1d4 acid damage as the acid on the floor burns exposed flesh.

Four **serpentfolk** (see appendix A) stand guard here, blocking access to area 5-3 and the ritual that is in progress. On a successful DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) check, characters can overhear the chanting emanating from the south.

AREA 5-3: SACRIFICE AND SUMMONING

The hellish glow of magma gives this volcanic chamber a sinister cast. Pools of magma and miniature lava domes radiate massive amounts of heat here, and the air is filled with floating motes of ash floating amidst the harsh brimstone vapors of volcanic gasses. A stone altar has been erected at the far south end of the chamber. A simple representation of a cobra-headed being is carved into the cavern wall behind it. A trio of humans are chained to the altar, feebly struggling against their bonds.

When the chamber is first entered, the three **serpentfolk** cult members (see appendix A) are in the midst of sacrificing the three humans to Nehebkau. One of the serpentfolk wears heavy leather gloves and holds a massive ladle filled with molten rock. In the first round he pours the magma onto the first sacrifice, killing them and dedicating their soul to the ancient serpent god. This is repeated every two rounds, with the cultist refilling the ladle on the next round, and then emptying it on the following round. Should that cultist be slain, one of the others takes his place, pausing for a round to don the protective gloves before resuming the sacrificial cycle. Should the three humans be slain in this manner, the ritual is completed, and the cult successfully summons Nehebkau (a **magma viper**) on the following round.

While the acolytes of Nehebkau carry out the sacrifice, Lyanjenlys engages the party, working to keep them at bay. She defaults to attacking with *scorching ray,* launching torrents of magma from the available pools, and directing them at her targets. Just prior to the characters' arrival here, Lyanjenlys cast *protection from energy* (fire) on herself.

LYANJENLYS

Lyanjenlys is a cobra-headed serpentfolk wizard, benefactress of the demon Nehebkau, and leader of this rebellious sect of serpentfolk. Lyanjenlys has replaced several prominent figures throughout the archipelago with subordinate serpentfolk to destabilize the region and is very close to summoning her demon patron, Nehebkau, to this world.

LYAJENLYS

Medium Humanoid (Serpentfolk), Chaotic Evil

Armor Class: 17 (serpent half plate armor)

Hit Points: 84 (13d8 + 26)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	16 (+3)	20 (+5)

Skills: Deception +7, Perception +5, Stealth +4

Damage Immunities: poison

Condition Immunities: poisoned

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13

Languages: Common, Draconic

Challenge: 3 (700 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

ACTIONS

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution save or be blinded for 1d4 + 1 rounds.

Scimitar: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 8 (1d6 + 5) slashing damage.

Spit: Lyanjenlys spits poison in a line that is 40 feet long and 5 feet wide. One creature in that line selected by Lyanjenlys must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution save or be blinded for 1d4 + 1 rounds.

Hypnosis: When Lyanjenlys isn't incapacitated and can make eye contact with an intelligent creature within 30 feet, she can force the creature to make a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw. A creature that fails the save is charmed by Lyanjenlys (as per the *charm person* spell) for 1d4 hours and appears as if in a daze during that time.

Unless surprised, a creature can avert its eyes to avoid the saving throw at the start of its turn. If the creature does so, it can't see Lyanjenlys until the start of its next turn, when it can avert its eyes again.

Innate Spellcasting (1/day): Lyanjenlys can innately cast *alter self* (change appearance only), requiring no material components using Charisma as the spellcasting ability.

Spellcasting: Lyanjenlys casts one of the following spells, using Intelligence as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 12, +4 to hit with spell attacks).

- 3/day each: *burning hands*, *shield*
- 1/day each: *glyph of warding*, *protection from energy, scorching ray*

This cobra-headed humanoid presents an intimidating visage, clad in gleaming half plate armor and wielding a curved scimitar.

MAGMA VIPER

This cunning demon has the appearance of a giant snake burning with an inner fire. Unlike many other demons, magma vipers can speak Common with surprising proficiency. Although wingless, the creatures are capable of flight, which only serves to accentuate their disconcerting appearance.

MAGMA VIPER

Large Fiend (Demon), Typically Chaotic Evil

Armor Class: 16 (natural armor)

Hit Points: 76 (8d10 + 32)

Speed: 30 ft., fly 30 ft. (hover)

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
17 (+3)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)	14 (+2)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws: Dex +4

Skills: Perception +3

Damage Resistance: acid, cold, fire; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical weapons

Damage Immunities: poison

Condition Immunities: poisoned

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13

Languages: Abyssal, Common

Challenge: 3 (700 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

ACTIONS

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) piercing damage.

Flame Jet: The magma viper exhales fire in a 100-foot line that is 5 feet wide. Each creature in that line must make a DC 13 Dexterity saving throw, taking 3 (1d6) fire damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one. Those that fail the save catch fire and continue to take 3 (1d6) fire damage per round until they extinguish the flames by succeeding on a DC 13 Dexterity save.

Innate Spellcasting: The magma viper casts *darkness* at will, requiring no material components and using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 11).

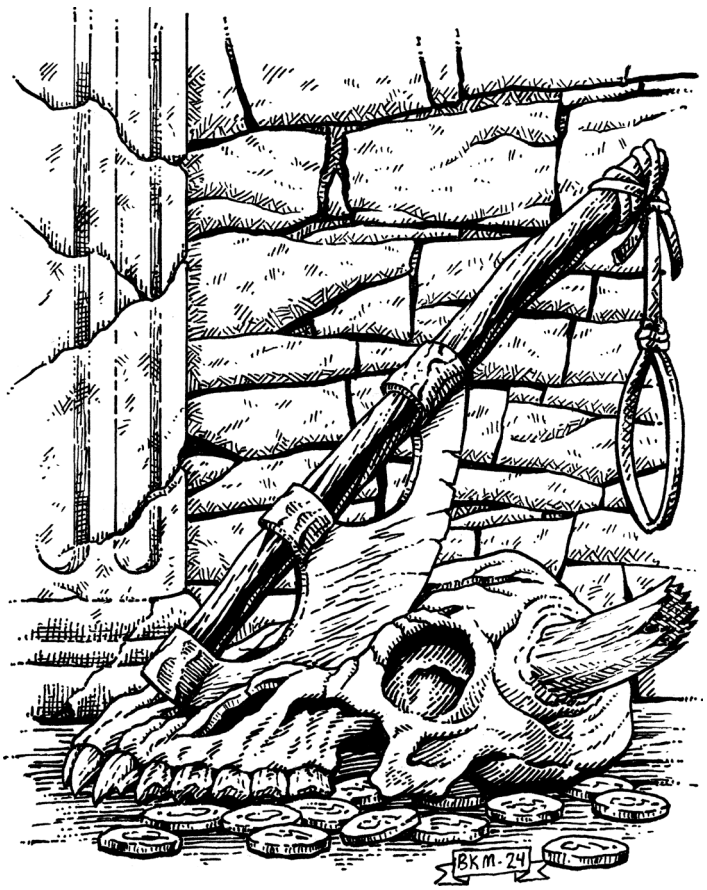
This large serpent emits an orange glow from its eyes, mouth, and from between its scales, giving one the impression that its physical form is simply a container filled with molten magma.

AREA 6-1: VENGEFUL MINION

The ramp descends to a twenty-foot diameter shaft, disappearing into darkness. A hot wind howls up from somewhere below, carrying with it the scent of brimstone. Every visible surface here glistens with moisture, making for treacherous footing. Frescoes along the walls leading to this chamber depict serpentfolk hurling a sacrifice into a yawning pit, and a serpentfolk wreathed in flames rising in response.

The moisture here is a combination of humidity and volcanic gasses from below, combining to create a sheen of sulfuric acid over everything. Slowly descending the ramp from area 5-1 requires a successful DC 10 Dexterity save to avoid falling prone and suffering 1d4 acid damage. Attempting to move at normal speed increases the difficulty to DC 12 and results in an uncontrolled slide towards the sacrificial lava tube. Those failing the roll go over the edge and fall 20 feet before landing on a small outcropping of stone (suffering 2d6 bludgeoning damage).

The frescoes depict the summoning of a **minion of Set**. Should a living human be cast into the pit (or accidentally fall from the ledge), the demon rises from the depths, immediately moving towards area 5-3 to destroy the heretical sect of serpentfolk. Of course, when that battle is done, should anyone remain behind, they too will be hunted and slain by the demon.



MINION OF SET

Medium fiend (demon, shapechanger), Chaotic Evil

Armor Class: 20 (plate armor and shield)

Hit Points: 55 (10d8 + 10)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
16 (+3)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	13 (+1)

Damage Resistance: acid, cold, fire

Damage Immunities: lightning, poison, psychic

Condition Immunities: frightened, poisoned

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 11

Languages: Abyssal, Common

Challenge: 4 (1,100 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

Dueling: When wielding a weapon in one hand and no other weapons, a minion of Set gets +2 to damage rolls with that weapon.

Improved Critical: A minion of Set scores a critical hit on a 19-20.

Magic Resistance: The minion of Set has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Shapechange (1/Day): A minion of Set can use its action to polymorph into a **giant constrictor snake** or a **giant poisonous snake**. It can revert to its true form as an action. It takes on the statistics of the creature as if using the spell polymorph. It reverts to its true form if it dies.

ACTIONS

Multiattack: The minion of Set makes two Khopesh attacks.

Khopesh: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 10 (1d8 + 5) slashing damage. The minion can forgo dealing damage to instead force the target to make a DC 13 Strength saving throw or drop its weapon or shield (minion of Set's choice).

REACTIONS

Cleave: If a minion of Set reduces a target to 0 or fewer hit points, it can use its reaction to make another attack on a different target within 5 feet of it.

This fiendish humanoid has scales covering its serpentine face. It wears bronze plate armor and carries a shield emblazoned with a coiled cobra about to strike.

AREA 6-2: THE EXCAVATION

Both ends of this passageway are choked off with rubble, with signs of a major collapse blocking things off for a great distance. A pair of serpentfolk, armed with whips, drive a work party of ten emaciated humans who work with pickaxes and shovels to excavate the passages.

The forces of the Shadow Kingdom collapsed these tunnels to seal off Lyanjenlys' access and to prevent their pawns (the characters) from discovering the greater underground passages leading to the Shadow Kingdom's seat of power beneath the isle. Manual excavation will take months to clear the passages.

The two **serpentfolk** (see appendix A) stationed here also carry whips:

- **Whip:** *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 10 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) slashing damage.

If the serpentfolk are attacked, the 10 prisoners (treat as **commoners**, each with 1 hit point remaining) rise and join the combat, weakly attempting to aid in their own liberation from the serpentfolk. The serpentfolk will, should the opportunity arise, use their Hypnosis ability to turn the prisoners against the party.

AREA 6-3: UNDERSEA GROTTO

The air here is cool and carries with it the tang of salt water. This edge of this natural undersea grotto is made of jagged volcanic rock, its blackness nearly blending into the dark seawater lapping at its edge.

Should the characters have a means of safely traversing the passage beneath the surface, they emerge into the seas of the Starry Archipelago at area C, albeit nearly 200 feet below the surface. While it's impossible to navigate the passage by merely holding one's breath, magical assistance may allow for this means of escape.

The waters here are also home to a **giant crab**, which scavenges the outer seabed before returning. Any disturbance of the water draws the creature's attention, and it immediately attacks. Below the surface, near the shore, are the remains of its carrion meals and surviving goods. The pile contains the partial skeletons of 40 sailors, dozens of rusty and useless swords and daggers, and a rotting chest.

Treasure. The rotting chest contains 2,000 gp but is secured by a rusty lock which requires a successful DC 18 Dexterity check with thieves' tools to open. Alternately, the wood is so rotten that it may easily be smashed open (AC 15, 3 hit points, immunity to poison and psychic damage), leaving the lock intact.

UNDERWATER COMBAT

Before running this encounter, it might be wise to review these rules on underwater combat.

Suffocating: A creature can hold its breath for a number of minutes equal to 1 + its Constitution modifier (minimum of 30 seconds). When a creature runs out of breath, it can survive for a number of rounds equal to its Constitution modifier (minimum of 1 round). At the start of its next turn, it drops to 0 hit points and is dying, and it can't regain hit points or be stabilized until it can breathe again.

Movement: When swimming, each foot of movement costs one extra foot unless the creature has a swim speed.

Melee Weapon Attacks: Creatures without a swim speed have disadvantage on attack rolls unless the weapon is a dagger, javelin, shortsword, spear, or trident.

Ranged Weapon Attacks: Ranged weapon attacks automatically fail beyond normal range. Against targets within normal range, attack rolls are at disadvantage unless the weapon is a crossbow, net, or weapon that is thrown like a javelin (including spears, tridents, and darts).

Fire Resistance: Creatures and objects fully immersed in water have resistance to fire damage.

CONCLUDING THE ADVENTURE

With the defeat of Lyanjenlys, and the rescue of any surviving prisoners, the truth of the abductions is revealed. Word quickly spreads and the rising tensions of the region soon return to their normal state. The characters are thanked for forever finishing off the remnants of the vile serpentfolk, and the governments of the archipelago develop a sense of complacency.

If Lyanjenlys has managed to escape, the party has made a formidable adversary who may bedevil them in the future. Furthermore, they have come to the notice of the Shadow Kingdom, which will certainly attempt to use them as pawns in their future machinations.

Awarding Experience. In addition to the experience earned for defeating creatures, award each character an additional 10 XP for each rescued captive. If the characters complete this adventure's quest and have not already earned enough experience to gain a level, consider allowing them to advance to the next level.

APPENDIX A: NEW MONSTERS

SERPENTFOLK

Once vanquished millennia ago by the Elder Race, these secretive snake-headed men now lead cults of Set, god of serpents, within the cities of man. They use magic to take the form of humans, and in this guise rule their Shadow Kingdom—the secret government of serpentfolk imposters who assassinate and then impersonate dukes, kings, and earls throughout the land. Their true form is revealed upon death, when their illusionary human features revert to a serpent's head. Until then, the only way to detect a serpentfolk imposter without magic is to state a certain primordial phrase known to their ancient druidic enemies—a phrase which the jaws of a true man can pronounce, but which the bones of a serpentfolk's mouth cannot form.

Serpentfolk have human bodies with snake's heads. Once per day, a serpentfolk can cast an illusion that causes its head to appear like that of a specific person. The illusion is complete, including visual, tactile, auditory, and olfactory elements, but the serpentfolk can reveal their true form if they so wish.

Serpentfolk can hypnotize lesser creatures. Any intelligent creature that looks into the serpentfolk's eyes is susceptible. The hypnosis works even when the serpentfolk is under illusion. Hypnotized creatures appear as if in a daze and will perform tasks as commanded while under the control of a serpentfolk.

Serpentfolk fight with weapons and, if revealed, with their bites, but they prefer skullduggery to combat. They are frequently encountered being led by wizards who specialize in illusion magic.

A limited number of serpentfolk live in primitive villages on isolated islands, having de-evolved after long ago being abandoned by and isolated from their brethren. These primeval serpentfolk are distrustful of outsiders, but generally not hostile unless threatened.

SERPENTFOLK

Medium Humanoid (Serpentfolk), Typically Lawful Neutral

Armor Class: 12 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 26 (4d8 + 8)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	15 (+2)	20 (+5)

Skills: Deception +7, Perception +4, Stealth +3

Damage Immunities: poison

Condition Immunities: poisoned

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 12

Languages: Common, Draconic

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

ACTIONS

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage, and the target must make a DC 14 Constitution saving throw. On a failure, the target suffers a poison effect that varies per individual serpentfolk (roll a 1d4):

1. Blindness- the target is blinded for 1 minute.
2. Weakness- the target suffers disadvantage on all Strength based attack rolls, ability checks and saving throws until a Long Rest is completed.
3. Painful spasms inflict 1d6 poison damage, and the target's speed is reduced by 10 feet for 1 hour due to muscle fatigue.
4. Paralysis- the target is paralyzed for 1 minute. The target can repeat the saving throw at the end of its turn, ending the effect with a success.

Scimitar: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) slashing damage.

Hypnosis: When the serpentfolk isn't incapacitated and can make eye contact with an intelligent creature within 30 feet, it can force the creature to make a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw. A creature that fails the save is charmed by the serpentfolk (as per the *charm person* spell) for 1d4 hours and appears as if in a daze during that time.

Unless surprised, a creature can avert its eyes to avoid the saving throw at the start of its turn. If the creature does so, it can't see the serpentfolk until the start of its next turn, when it can avert its eyes again.

Innate Spellcasting (1/day): The serpentfolk can innately cast *alter self* (change appearance only), requiring no material components. Their innate spellcasting ability is Charisma.

This snake-headed humanoid wears leather armor and brandishes a scimitar.

GM Note. The standard serpentfolk in this adventure are all Chaotic Evil and have the painful spasms poisonous effect to their bite.

COBRA-HEADED SERPENTFOLK SUB-COMMANDER

Medium Humanoid (Serpentfolk), Typically Chaotic Evil

Armor Class: 13 (leather armor)

Hit Points: 52 (8d8 + 16)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	20 (+5)

Skills: Deception +7, Perception +5, Stealth +4

Damage Immunities: poison

Condition Immunities: poisoned

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13

Languages: Common, Draconic

Challenge: 1 (200 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

ACTIONS

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage, and the target must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution save or be blinded for 1d4 - 1 rounds (minimum 1).

Scimitar: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) slashing damage.

Spit: The serpentfolk spits poison in a line that is 30 feet long and 5 feet wide. One creature in that line selected by the serpentfolk must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution save or be blinded for 1d4 - 1 rounds (minimum 1).

Hypnosis: When the serpentfolk isn't incapacitated and can make eye contact with an intelligent creature within 30 feet, it can force the creature to make a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw. A creature that fails the save is charmed by the serpentfolk (as per the *charm person* spell) for 1d4 hours and appears as if in a daze during that time.

Unless surprised, a creature can avert its eyes to avoid the saving throw at the start of its turn. If the creature does so, it can't see the serpentfolk until the start of its next turn, when it can avert its eyes again.

Innate Spellcasting (1/day): The serpentfolk can innately cast *alter self* (change appearance only), requiring no material components. Their innate spellcasting ability is Charisma.

The serpentine head of this intimidating humanoid includes a distinctively scaled hood, much like that of a cobra. Clad in leather armor, it brandishes a scimitar.

PRIMEVAL SERPENTFOLK

Medium Humanoid (Serpentfolk), Typically Neutral

Armor Class: 13 (hide armor)

Hit Points: 30 (4d8 + 12)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHR
16 (+3)	13 (+1)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

Skills: Perception +1, Stealth +3, Survival +1

Damage Immunities: poison

Condition Immunities: poisoned

Senses: darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages: Common, Draconic

Challenge: 1/2 (100 XP) **Proficiency Bonus:** +2

ACTIONS

Bite: *Melee Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) piercing damage plus 3 (1d6) poison damage.

Obsidian Spear: *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack*: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage, or 7 (1d8 + 3) piercing damage if used with two hands to make a melee attack.

Hypnosis: When the serpentfolk isn't incapacitated and can make eye contact with an intelligent creature within 30 feet, it can force the creature to make a DC 14 Wisdom saving throw. A creature that fails the save is charmed by the serpentfolk (as per the *charm person* spell) for 1d4 hours and appears as if in a daze during that time.

Unless surprised, a creature can avert its eyes to avoid the saving throw at the start of its turn. If the creature does so, it can't see the serpentfolk until the start of its next turn, when it can avert its eyes again.

This primitive humanoid, clad in hides and clutching a stone spear, has a head resembling that of a snake.

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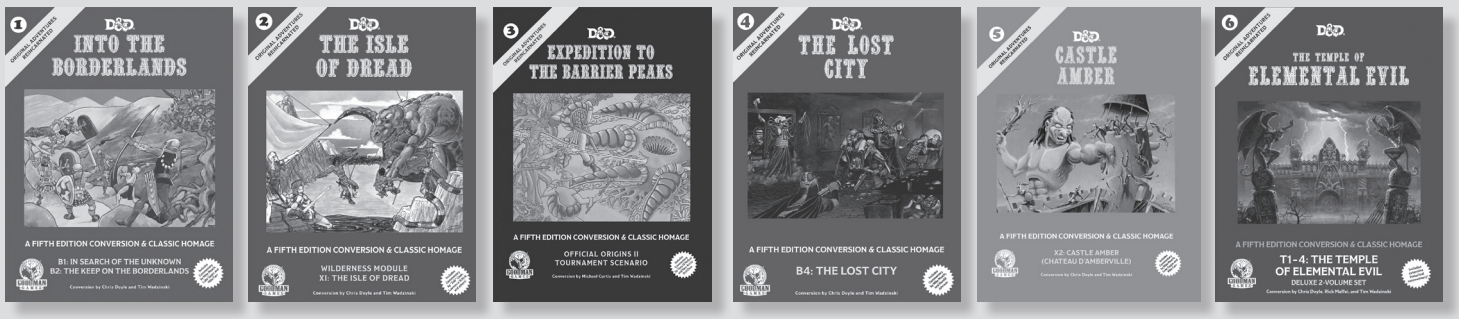

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